

Declawed Cat Litter Box Pain — Action Checklist

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UNDERSTAND YOUR CAT'S PAIN

- ☐ **Understand the Amputation:** Recognize that declawing removed the last bone in each of your cat's toes, meaning every step puts pressure directly on exposed bone and nerve endings rather than protected tissue.
- ☐ **Recognize Phantom Pain:** Watch for obsessive paw licking, sudden paw shaking, or resistance to having paws touched, as these indicate phantom nerve sensations your cat genuinely experiences.
- ☐ **Identify Pain Association:** Understand that your cat has learned to avoid the litter box because digging in litter causes pain at her amputation sites, and this learned fear reinforces the behavior.
- ☐ **Rule Out Medical Issues:** Rule out urinary tract infections and other health problems with your veterinarian before assuming the litter box issue is purely behavioral rather than pain-driven.

MODIFY THE LITTER BOX

- ☐ **Switch to Paper-Based Litter:** Replace clay or silica litter with paper-based options like Yesterday's News or Carefresh, which are soft and dust-free for sensitive paws.
- ☐ **Avoid Clay Litter:** Clay litter's rigid, clumping texture applies uneven pressure to exposed toe bones and nerves, making natural digging behavior painful for your cat.
- ☐ **Fill Box to Comfortable Depth:** Add enough litter so your cat can cover waste without her sensitive paws touching the hard box bottom, which can jab at exposed tissue.
- ☐ **Eliminate Dusty Litter:** Avoid dusty litters that can irritate exposed surgical sites and open tissue in the toe amputation areas, adding unnecessary pain to every box visit.

GET VETERINARY SUPPORT

- ☐ **Schedule a Paw Examination:** Have your veterinarian check the amputation sites for bone spurs, scar tissue, or nerve damage that may cause ongoing pain your cat cannot express directly.
 - ☐ **Discuss Phantom Pain Treatment:** Ask your vet about managing phantom pain or nerve irritation with medications or supplements designed for amputees that can reduce your cat's discomfort.
 - ☐ **Monitor for Gait Changes:** Watch for limping, hesitation, or unusual walking patterns that signal secondary joint problems from altered paw mechanics and compensation for pain.
 - ☐ **Provide Soft Resting Areas:** Place soft beds and blankets around your home to give your cat comfortable surfaces for resting her sensitive paws away from hard floors.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.